behind. But before that, I persuade him to stop at a popular stall where I order a round of Banarasi kachauri, jalebi and lassi, among the foods the city is justly famous for. We laugh at how adding ‘Banarasi’ before any item seems to raise its allure, such as paan, thandai, mangoes, pickles and papads, not to mention sarees, carpets, brassware and perfumes.

Santosh strikes me as a kind, self-effacing, god-fearing man of high-minded principles, devoted to his community’s welfare. He commands much respect among his people. Over the next three hours, he talks about Mallah life and society, some of it also discussed by anthropologist Assa Doron in his excellent *Life on the Ganga: Boatmen and the Ritual Economy of Banaras*.

Santosh animatedly tells me about his community’s triumphant yet rollercoaster protest campaign in early 2019 against the state government, which had licensed a private corporation to launch a double-decker cruise ship in Varanasi, the first of many planned. Called Alaknanda, the ship offered food, music, AC, toilets and on-board priests for conducting rituals. The Mallahs saw it as a Trojan Horse and protested by shutting down all boating for days. According to Santosh, the government even tried to divide them to break their strike, but the Mallahs held firm and prevailed.[37] At least for now. The cruise ships, Santosh adds, would’ve threatened their livelihoods, opened the riverfront to non-Mallah boatmen and destroyed the foundations of the Mallah community by exposing them to unbridled economic competition where the strong would trample the weak.

A sympathetic outsider might root for the little guys against the corporation, but the reality is more complex, writes Doron. While all Mallahs are entitled to seek a living from the larger riverfront economy, only a few have the right to own boats. These are the *ghatwar*s, who, between them, monopolize all boat ownership along the river. These rights are hereditary and pass down in patrilineal succession. The ghatwars fiercely defend these rights. Many own multiple boats. On the large and lucrative Assi Ghat, for instance, just four ghatwar families own all of the boats.[38] This inequity is a frequent source of friction in the community. While ghatwars invite other Mallahs to drive their boats on a fifty-fifty revenue-sharing basis, it’s clear that theirs is the more secure, powerful and prosperous subgroup in the community.